FARIA · 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · A LESSON FOR JEFF FRANZEN

Bounty: mutiny, survival, and the people of Pitcairn

On 28 April 1789 Fletcher Christian took HMS Bounty from William Bligh. Bligh and eighteen others were put in the launch. Not everyone left aboard had chosen the mutiny in the same way, and not every man in the boat was a loyal volunteer in a simple story. The ship's jobs, nursery and boat, are the ships lesson. This page is what people did.

Bligh could navigate. He was also harsh to his company. A court later acquitted him of losing the ship. An acquittal says the Navy did not convict him. It does not wash the temper out of the record.

At Tofua on 2 May his own narrative is the one we have. He had told his men to agree on a cover: the ship had sunk on 1 May. Islanders tried to haul the boat ashore, and Bligh brandished a cutlass. When he refused to stay the night, a chief threatened them. John Norton ran up the beach to cast off the stern line, though he was called back. As the crew boarded, the attack began. Norton was struck down. Bligh cut the rope with a pocket knife. Bligh inferred that the visitors meant to take the boat and the stores, and that they had learned the party had no firearms. That is his inference. There is no account here from Tofua, and there is no proven single provocation that rests on Norton alone.

They reached Timor. Not every man of the launch lived to see England again.

In January 1790 nine British mutineers, six Polynesian men, twelve women, and an infant came to Pitcairn. Infant counts vary, and this page will not pretend they do not. People had lived on the island before. It was empty then. The Bounty was burned on 23 January. The Pitcairn government describes the Polynesian men as treated more like slaves than like partners. Land, weapons, and the women's choices were not shared. In September 1793 five of the mutineers were killed: Christian, Mills, Martin, Williams, and Brown. By 1794 all six Polynesian men were dead. Later tellings disagree about who struck whom. McCoy killed himself in 1798. Young and Adams killed Quintal in 1799. Young died in 1800. Adams lived until 1829, the last of the mutineers, not the author of a peaceful idyll. The women and the children are the center of what continued.

The American ship Topaz, under Mayhew Folger, found the settlement in 1808. In 1831 a removal to Tahiti brought disease and deaths, then a return. In 1856 the community went to Norfolk Island. Some families came back to Pitcairn later. Head counts differ by source, so this lesson will not pick a false exact number. Descendants live on both islands. The breadfruit those ships were built to move is the next lesson in the chain.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Royal Museums Greenwich, the mutiny and Bligh: https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/mutiny-on-bounty and https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/william-bligh
- William Bligh, A Voyage to the South Sea (Project Gutenberg): https://www.gutenberg.org/cache/epub/15411/pg15411.txt
- Government of Pitcairn, history: https://www.government.pn/history
- Maike Gauger and others, on Pitcairn's early years, ANU Press: https://press-files.anu.edu.au/downloads/press/n2159/pdf/ch06.pdf

Key facts

- The mutiny was 28 April 1789. Bligh and 18 others took the launch. Not everyone remaining aboard was a willing mutineer in the same sense.
- At Tofua on 2 May, Norton was killed while casting off the stern line. Bligh's book is the account we have. It infers motive. It is not a Tongan testimony.
- Pitcairn, January 1790: nine British mutineers, six Polynesian men, twelve women, and an infant. The ship was burned on 23 January.
- By 1794 the Polynesian men were dead and five mutineers had been killed. Adams was the last surviving mutineer, not the whole community.